

Gavin Robert Foster

foste362 AT purdue DOT edu ❖ West Lafayette, IN

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- **Philosophy of Mind/Cognitive Science**
- **Comparative/Developmental Psychology**
- **Philosophy of Biology**
- Kant's Theoretical and Moral Philosophy
- History and Philosophy of Science
- History of Analytic Philosophy

PUBLICATIONS

- Bastos, Amalia P. M., Gavin Robert Foster, and Christopher Krupenye. 2026. "Do dogs rationally infer the causes of failed actions?" *PLOS One* 21 (2): e0341872. doi:10.1371/journal.pone.0341872.
- Foster, Gavin Robert, and Evan Westra. 2026. Review of the book *Acting for Reasons: In Defence of Common-Sense Psychology*, by Emma Borg. *Mind*.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. 2025. "From Monkeys to Infants: The Empirical Challenges Facing Mental Fictionalism." *Philosophical Psychology*. doi:10.1080/09515089.2025.2556845.

EDUCATION

Purdue University

August 2024 – June 2030

PhD (Philosophy)

West Lafayette, IN

- One of four incoming students selected as a Dean's Graduate Fellow in the College of Liberal Arts
 - "The graduate fellows are expected to contribute to the strategic effort of the College to support excellence in research at all levels. These high-level, highly-competitive graduate fellowships recruit top-flight graduate students to work alongside – and in support of – faculty whose scholarship will elevate the research profile of the College and contribute to important campus AAU metrics."

Johns Hopkins University

May 2023 – November 2023; February 2024 – July 2024

Visiting Graduate Scholar, Department of Psychology and Brain Sciences

Baltimore, MD

- Supervised and trained by Professor Christopher Krupenye, head of the Social and Cognitive Origins Group
- Aided in the launch of the Canine Minds Collaborate (the group's new on-site dog lab)
 - Helped design and implement several theory of mind experiments on dogs
- Remains an affiliate of the Social and Cognitive Origins Group

Carleton University

September 2022 – May 2024

MA (Philosophy)

Toronto, ON

- Completed MA Thesis; Nominated for Senate Medal: "Mindreading in Great Apes: Dissolving the Logical Problem and a New Multiple Soft-Indicators Model."
 - Supervisors: Myrto Mylopoulos, Andrew Brook (cross-listed in the departments of philosophy and cognitive science)

University of Toronto

June 2022

BA with Honor's, Major (Philosophy), Minors (History and Philosophy of Science; Indigenous Studies)

Toronto, ON

- Attending university at the age of sixteen, became a winner of the Governor General's medal in 2017.
- My upper-year philosophy undergraduate work was primarily concerned with the intersection of language and mind. In particular, I conducted research on Davidson's philosophy of mind and language, as well as on Bayesian philosophy of science, under the supervision of Professor Franz Huber.

SELECTED GRANTS, AWARDS & HONOURS

- Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology
 - Student Award for Best Graduate Paper in Philosophy (2026)
- Purdue University
 - PROMISE Grant for “Animal Minds: New Theories and New Observations” (January 2026)
 - PROMISE Grant for “Triadic Approaches in Philosophy of Science: Revealing the ‘Gloss’ of Mental Representations Without Succumbing to Fictionalism” (December 2024)
 - Dean’s Graduate Fellow (2024-2030)
 - SSHRC CGS-D (2024-2028)
 - For the project “Middle-Ground Conceptualism, Non-Human Animals, and Persistent Challenges in Comparative Psychology”
 - Score: 11.07/12
- Carleton University
 - Dr. Thomas Betz Memorial Award (February 2024)
 - Michel Gaulin Travel Bursary in the Humanities (December 2023)
 - SSHRC Michael Smith Foreign Study Supplement (November 2023)
 - SSHRC CGS-M Grant (April 2023)
 - For the project “The Emergence of Thought: Continual or All-at-Once
 - Ontario Graduate Scholarship Grant (April 2023)
 - Margaret Wade Labarge Fund (2022)
 - Departmental Entrance Scholarships (2022)
- University of Toronto, Trinity College
 - The Chancellor R. C. Berkinshaw Scholarship (2017)
 - Dean’s List (Multiple)
 - Douglas Bond Symons Prize in Philosophy (for highest graduating GPA in philosophy across all years) (2022)
 - Drew Thompson Scholarship (2020)
 - University of Toronto Scholar (2017)

SELECTED CONFERENCE & TALKS

- Foster, Gavin Robert. June 2026. “The Pluralistic Evolution of Factive Mindreading.” *Canadian Philosophy Association Congress*. Halifax, Nova Scotia.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. April 2026. “Factive Mindreading and Species of Knowledge.” *33rd International Conference on Comparative Cognition*. Montreal, Quebec.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. February 2026. “A Pluralistic Account of the Evolutionary Origins of Knowledge Attribution.” *Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology 2026*. Atlanta, Georgia.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. February 2026. “A Pluralistic Account of the Evolutionary Origins of Knowledge Attribution.” *Rub-University Bochum & London School of Economics Joint Workshop on Animal Minds*. Bochum, Germany.
- Foster, Gavin Robert, and Evan Westra. July 2025. “Desire Without Metarepresentation.” *Society for Philosophy and Psychology 2025*. Ithaca, New York.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. April 2025. “What Do Monkeys Know About Knowledge?” *Southern Society for Philosophy and Psychology 2025*. Mobile, Alabama.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. March 2025. “Reconsidering Factive Accounts of Monkey Mindreading.” *32nd International*

Conference on Comparative Cognition. Albuquerque, New Mexico.

- Foster, Gavin Robert. January 2025. "The Logical Problem of Mindreading: A New Middle-Ground Account." *The First Annual Association Association Conference*. Gainesville, Florida.
- [Invited] Foster, Gavin Robert. December 2024. "Reconsidering Behavioural Accounts of Theory of Mind in Great Apes." *8th Panhellenistic Conference on Philosophy of Science*. Athens, Greece.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. November 2024. "Why Animal Mindreading Undermines Fictionalism about Folk Psychology." *Workshop on Interpretivism, Mental Fictionalism, and Folk Psychology*. Tartu, Estonia.
- [Invited] Foster, Gavin Robert. July 2024. "A New Kantian Model of Animal Representation." *Society for European Philosophy Conference 2024*. Cardiff, United Kingdom.
- Foster, Gavin Robert, and Andrew Brook. June 2024. "Kant and Evolution: Deciphering Animal Cognition." *CPA 2024 (Canadian Philosophy Association Congress)*. Montreal, Canada.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. August 2023. "Davidson on Animal Minds: Weakening Morgan's Canon." *11th European Conference for Analytic Philosophy*. Vienna, Austria.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. July 2023. "Davidson and Wittgenstein on Animal Minds: A Pluralistic Approach to Conceptualization." *6th Early Career Researchers Workshop in Philosophy of Mind and Cognitive Science*. Bochum, Germany.
- Foster, Gavin Robert. April 2023. "Pattern realism as a possible solution to the logical problem in animal mindreading." *Carleton Cognitive Science Graduate Conference 2023*. Ottawa, Canada.

RELEVANT WORK EXPERIENCE

Purdue University

August 2025 – August 2026

Lecturer

West Lafayette, IN

- PHIL[TBD]: What Animals Tell Us About Human Nature (Summer 2026)
- PHIL29300-001: Philosophical Investigations Through Videogames (Summer 2025; Summer 2026)
- PHIL29300-002: AI and You (Summer 2025)

Carleton University

September 2022 – April 2024

Teaching Assistant

Ottawa, ON

- PHIL2001A/PHIL2001B: Introduction to Logic (Fall 2022; Fall 2023; Winter 2024)
- LING2504/PHIL2504: Language and Communication (Winter 2023)
- LING3504A/PHIL3504A: Pragmatics (Winter 2023)

Esprit Academy – Toronto Private Day School

September 2020 – December 2020

Teaching Assistant

Toronto, ON

- Worked 8 hours a day with disabled children ranging from ages 5 to 12, lecturing and teaching in subjects like mathematics, English, history, geography, and science.
- Managed mental health crises for children on the spectrum with sensory disorders or ADHD.
- Ceased operation due to the COVID-19 pandemic.

EXTRACURRICULAR EXPERIENCE

Almagest Undergraduate Journal for the History and Philosophy of Science

Sept. 2018 – Aug. 2021

Senior Editor (Sept. 2018 – Aug. 2019)

Toronto, ON

Editor-in-Chief (Aug. 2019 – Aug. 2021)

Noesis Undergraduate Journal for Philosophy

Sept. 2018 – Aug. 2021

Junior Editor (Sept. 2018 – Aug. 2019)

Toronto, ON

Senior Editor (Aug. 2019 – Aug. 2020)

Editor-in-Chief (Aug. 2020 – Aug. 2021)

History and Philosophy of Science Undergraduate Society (HPSUS)
Vice-President

Sept. 2019 – Aug. 2020
Toronto, ON